Bhopal, for example, party MP Alok Sharma has been running a campaign against the erstwhile ruling family, blaming the last nawab Hamidullah Khan for delaying the merger and harbouring plans to join Pakistan post-Independence, a charge that has often been levelled against non-Muslim princely states too. And who can forget the furore caused by senior BJP leader Parshottam Rupala shortly before the 2024 election, when his remark that the erstwhile maharajas capitulated to Britishers, broke bread with them and even married off their daughters to them, had the entire Kshatriya community up in arms. Rupala was nonetheless fortunate to win his constituency Rajkot that year. Also worth noting is the BJP government's 2019 amendment to the Arms Act, which reduced the number of licenced weapons an individual can possess from three to two. A similar move during the UPA era had been stalled following interventions by MPs, particularly those from royal lineages.

PRINCELY PRAGMATISM

What do the royals themselves think of the BJP's outreach? "The blessings of the Almighty and our ancestors, as well as our conduct, have fortunately earned the continued confidence of the public. I am thankful to the party (BJP) and the people for giving me an opportunity to contribute to our country's development," says Vishvaraj. Digvijaya, however, doubts "the BJP's faith in the tenets of the Constitution, which espouses equality for all". Claiming that the party has a soft corner for royalty, he says: "As far as my family is concerned, we chose the path of democracy and did not join the Jana Sangh or the BJP, although they were very keen."

From a historical perspective, royalty, says a section of sociologists, has always aligned with the winning side. "Royalty, like political actors of all types, does survive through tactical alliances, etc. Just as we have politicians who are consummate survivors, so too are there royal dynasties that have managed to hold relevance despite all kinds of historical changes and challenges," says author Manu Pillai. "It is a bit simplistic to reduce the princely legacy to one of 'collaborators with the Raj'; it is like applying black and white lenses to present-day politics, which actually has many more layers and complexities."

MISSION MUSEUM

To showcase the contributions of princely states, the Gujarat government is building the Museum of Royal Kingdoms of India in Narmada district

2027
Scheduled year of opening

15 acres
Area of the campus

₹260 cr.
Estimated cost of the project

3
No. of main galleries
Indian Royalty, the Story of Integration and the Hall of Unity

Other Attractions

- Permanent and changing exhibitions
- Interactive and immersive displays
- Extensive facilities for tourists

ERSTWHILE ROYALTY ARE NOW POPULAR ON THE CONCLAVE CIRCUIT, AS WELL AS ON PODCASTS AND CHAT SHOWS

A ROYAL REVAMP

That said, royals are trying to reinvent themselves in the modern world. Zamindars and rajas—cast as evil and exploitative in the Bollywood films of the 1980s and '90s—are now increasingly celebrated in popular culture. Their public image has shifted, too, with erstwhile royals now regulars on the conclave circuit, on podcasts and chat shows. Radhika Raje Gaekwad of the former Baroda royal family was recently invited by a newspaper to write about an OTT show that did not paint a very charitable picture of her ilk. "There is definitely an allure, and it began when magazines like *Hello*, which had covered European royalty, came to India. The magazines featured royals on their covers and their palaces were opened up for people to see them through their pages. Social media, too, has a major role to play as it provides royals a platform to tell their stories like they wanted to," she says.

Anshu Khanna, a communication professional, says earlier, if a glossy featured an industrialist, a sportsperson and a professional, today it also covers a former royal as part of the spread. "Many among the younger lot of erstwhile royals have studied at foreign universities. Having returned, they are now pursuing careers relevant to the times and have played a major role in changing the narrative," says Khanna, who set up Royal Fables in 2010, a platform that showcases royal India.

"Our families are often subjected to statue politics, unwarranted comments and misrepresentation by politicians and the entertainment industry," says Vishvaraj. "True recognition will come when both historical and contemporary records are presented factually, and strict action is taken against those who malign our families and ancestors for personal or political gain."

Until then, the erstwhile rulers will throw their lot with the party that is the real ruler in exchange for preserving their political and cultural relevance. ■

–with Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Rohit Parihar, Jumana Shah and Arkamoy Datta Majumdar